The Contribution of the Project "From Parchment to Computer: Editing Manuscripts in the Digital Age" to Training in Digital Humanities

Lombardo, Elena
elenalombardo@edu.ulisboa.pt
Centro de Linguística da Universidade de Lisboa, Portugal

Bico, Maria Inês Monteiro
mariainesb1@edu.ulisboa.pt
Centro de Linguística da Universidade de Lisboa, Portugal

Coelho, Catarina
catarinacoelho1@edu.ulisboa.pt
Centro de História da Universidade de Lisboa, Portugal

Linked to a vertiginous acceleration in the development of Information Technology, the field of Digital Humanities (DH) has been growing as a multidisciplinary space of dialogue between traditional humanistic knowledge and the computer sciences. In Europe, the DiXiT project[1] (2014-2017) helped create a network of researchers focused on digital scholarly editing. Additionally, there is a broad range of short-term, intensive courses in this field, like the Antwerp Summer University in DH[2]; the BAL-ADRIA Summer School on DH[3] (Linnaeus University's iSchool and University of Zadar); the European Summer University in DH[4] (CLARIN and DARIAH); the DH & Research Software Engineering Summer School[5] (King's College London, University of Cambridge and University of Edinburgh, in collaboration with DISKAH project); the DH course at Oxford Summer School[6]; or the Summer School in DH at Università degli Studi di Modena e Reggio Emilia[7].

In the Portuguese national scene, there are several initiatives for training, self-reflection and dissemination of the various aspects of this discipline. Examples include the Master's Degree in DH at the University of Minho,[8] the DH Laboratory at the NOVA University of Lisbon,[9] and the activities of the Associação das Humanidades Digitais,[10] which finds a prolific hub in CIDEHUS at the University of Évora.[11] At the University of Lisbon, a working group in DH[12] was recently established, aiming to bring together, coordinate, and publicize the various projects in this field within the School of Arts and Humanities. This set of initiatives demonstrates the growing recognition of the field's importance and the collective effort to establish a solid foundation for research and teaching that fosters the development of the DH in Portugal.

Within this broader context, activities specifically dedicated to digital scholarly editing remain somewhat marginal. This is not to say that there are no significant examples: among them are the many projects made possible by the creation of the TEITOK platform by the Centro de Linguística da Universidade de Lisboa (CLUL);[13] the LdoD project by the University of Coimbra[14] and, more recently, the iForal project,[15] which links the Centro de História da Universidade de Lisboa with CLUL and involves five other institutions. However, despite the quality and growing number of such projects, digital scholarly editing in Portugal remains, to a great extent, tied to isolated and scattered initiatives.

Two significant gaps are evident in this field. On one hand, there is a lack of theoretical reflection: with the exception of a few articles, most of them not recent,[16] little has been written about the epistemological and methodological foundations of this area. On the other hand, national training initiatives in digital scholarly editing are rare. When they do occur, they tend to focus exclusively on the text encoding stage, neglecting other equally important phases, such as conceptual modeling, the construction of user interfaces, and the preparation of data search tools.

Based on these reflections, inspired by academic works such as Mahony / Pierazzo (2012) and Spiro (2012) and with the aim of broadening and deepening work in training, self-reflection, and the dissemination of Digital Philology, the initiative "From Parchment to Computer: Editing Manuscripts in the Digital Age"[17] was developed. This initiative, conceived within the framework of the Textual Criticism Program at the School of Arts and Humanities of the University of Lisbon, is structured into five short, modular, and interconnected courses on Textual Criticism and digital scholarly editing. The initiative serves a dual purpose: on the one hand, to equip participants with the knowledge and skills necessary to understand,

plan, and execute a digital scholarly edition at all stages; on the other, to promote and raise awareness, both within the academic community and the general public, of Digital Philology.

Each module aims at deepening participants' knowledge of certain aspects related to scholarly editing. The goal of the initiative, through its five articulated modules, is to provide a global understanding of what a digital scholarly edition entails — from theoretical aspects to technical ones. Although the modules are independent and can be attended separately, they are structured progressively, allowing participants to build on what they learn in earlier sessions. The five modules are:

- "Scholarly Editing: theories, methods and practices" – Focused on providing an overview of the theoretical and methodological foundations of Textual Criticism.
- "Reading Classics in the digital age" – Focused on the user experience while navigating digital editions, highlighting potentialities and good practices in using scholarly digital editions.
- "Digital Scholarly Editing – Part I: text encoding" – Introducing XML markup language, following the TEI standards. The goal is to give participants the ability to structure and encode texts for a scholarly digital edition.
- "Digital Scholarly Editing – Part II: user interaction and interfaces" – Focused on the essential technologies for creating an interactive and visually attractive digital edition. It covers basic fundamentals of CSS, HTML, XPath and XSLT.
- "Beyond editing: the digital paradigm in Linguistics research" – Introducing Natural Language Processing using Python. The goal is to present practical tools to perform textual analysis in Philology and Linguistics projects.

The first two modules are scheduled for January 2025 and focus on theoretical foundations, being designed for a wider audience. In contrast, the last three modules are hands-on and aim at a more specialized public. The third will be held in February 2025; while the fourth and fifth are planned for late June/early July 2025, and will be developed in partnership with other national and international universities.

Since the modules are aimed at a wide audience, the set of goals is quite diverse. The broader objective of the project is to draw the public's attention to scholarly digital editions, by giving them tools to navigate, understand and critically evaluate the resources available. For the academic audience, the goal is to provide a basic understanding of all the stages of creating a scholarly digital edition, while also presenting them the tools to elaborate one on their own.

In contrast to other projects linked to Masters and Doctoral programs or externally funded by other organizations, this is a self-financed initiative: courses are financed by participants, through their enrollment fees, resulting in a greater autonomy and the possibility to be held frequently. Courses are evaluated through metrics that include: a comparison between the number of enrollments and the number of effective participants; participants' feedback; evaluation of assignments completed during the course.

With multiple benefits, this initiative not only reinforces the role of the University of Lisbon within the field of the DH, differentiating its educational offer from the others, but it also promotes the interaction between society's different sectors while assuming the responsibility of demonstrating the importance and practical value of Textual Criticism in the digital age.

Through an integrated approach that combines theory, practice, applicability and autonomization, the project aims to contribute to the efforts to democratize access to digital technologies and to a critical understanding of its use in the field of the Humanities.

Notes

1. https://dixit.uni-koeln.de/
2. https://www.uantwerpen.be/en/summer-winter-schools/digital-humanities/
3. https://conference.unizd.hr/baladria2025/
4. https://esudh.github.io/
5. https://dhrse2025.er.kcl.ac.uk/
6. https://web.cvent.com/event/ac17dbdc-bf37-4057-adad-fab0de9a4577/summary
7. https://www.summerschooldigitalhumanities.unimore.it/2025-edition/
8. https://www.elach.uminho.pt/pt/estudar/Paginas/Mestrados/Humanidades-Digitais.aspx
9. https://dhlab.fcsh.unl.pt/
10. https://ahdig.hypotheses.org/
11. Cfr. the *Jornadas de Humanidades Digitais* , organised by CIDEHUS (https://sites.google.com/view/humanidades-digitais-cidehus/p%C3%A1gina-inicial).
12. This group is currently working informally and has not been yet formalised. The initiative is driven by the efforts of Dr. Filipa Roldão and Dr. Santiago Pérez Isasi.
13. TEITOK was first presented to the academic community in Janssen (2016). A list of these projects can be accessed on http://teitok.clul.ul.pt/.
14. As in Portela (2013) and the project's webpage < https://ldod.uc.pt/edition >

15. As in Roldão and Serafim (2021) and the project's webpage < https://iforal.hypotheses.org/ >
16. See, for example, Paixão de Sousa (2013).
17. https://filologiadigital.org

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